

Setting Up ElevenLabs

How to get an ElevenLabs API key and give it to ImageSkinForLLM, so the app can speak in the cloned voice. For Windows 11, macOS and Linux.

What you will do

1. Sign up for ElevenLabs and choose a plan that includes Instant Voice Cloning.
2. Create an API key (a long secret code that lets the app use your account).
3. Put the key in the `ELEVENLABS_API_KEY` environment variable, where ImageSkinForLLM reads it.
4. Run a quick test.

Time needed: about 10 minutes. You need an email address and a payment card.

Keep the key secret. Anyone with your key can use your ElevenLabs account and its credits. Never put it in a file you commit to Git, in a screenshot, in an email or in a chat message. If it leaks, delete it in ElevenLabs and create a new one.

ElevenLabs changes its website and plans from time to time. The menu names and plans below were checked against ElevenLabs' own help pages on 4 October 2026. If something looks different, look for the closest match.

Part 1. Sign up and choose a plan

- 1 Open `https://elevenlabs.io` in your web browser and click **Sign up**. Sign up with your email or with a Google account, then confirm your email if asked.
- 2 Choose a plan. **The free plan does not include Instant Voice Cloning**, which this app needs to make a voice from the voice sample. The cheapest plan that includes it is **Starter**. Check the current prices at `https://elevenlabs.io/pricing`.
- 3 To upgrade, click your profile or the plan name in the bottom-left corner, choose **Upgrade** (or **Subscription**), pick **Starter** or higher, and enter your payment details.

Consent. Only clone the voice of a person who has agreed to it. ElevenLabs' terms require that you have the right to use the voice you upload. ImageSkinForLLM uploads the voice sample to ElevenLabs the first time you run it.

Part 2. Create your API key

- 1 Signed in to ElevenLabs, click **Developers** in the left sidebar, then the **API Keys** tab. (Direct link: `https://elevenlabs.io/app/settings/api-keys`.)

2 Click **Create API Key** (or **Create Key**). Give it a name you will recognize, such as `ImageSkinForLLM_laptop`.

3 Leave **Restrict Key** turned on and allow only what the app needs:

Feature	Set to	Why the app needs it
Text to Speech	Access	Speaks each reply in the cloned voice.
Voices	Write	Creates the cloned voice from the voice sample.
Everything else	No access	Not used.

If you prefer, set a **credit limit** on the key so it can never use more than that amount.

4 Click **Create**. **The full key is shown only once**. Click the copy button and keep the key somewhere safe, such as a password manager. Afterwards ElevenLabs shows only its name and last four characters. If you lose it, delete it and create a new one.

Part 3. Give the key to ImageSkinForLLM

The app reads the key from the environment variable `ELEVENLABS_API_KEY`. It is deliberately **not** stored in `config.toml`, so the key never ends up in a file that could be committed. Pick one of the two options below. In every command, replace `your-key` with the key you copied, keeping the quotes where shown.

Option A. Just for the current terminal window

Good for trying things out. The key is forgotten when you close the window, so you set it again next time.

Windows 11, Command Prompt

```
set ELEVENLABS_API_KEY=your-key
```

No quotes and no spaces around `=` in Command Prompt.

Windows 11, PowerShell

```
$env:ELEVENLABS_API_KEY = "your-key"
```

macOS / Linux

```
export ELEVENLABS_API_KEY="your-key"
```

Option B. Saved for every new terminal window

Set it once and every terminal you open afterwards has it. **Close and reopen the terminal after this step**; windows that were already open don't see the change.

Windows 11, Command Prompt

```
setx ELEVENLABS_API_KEY "your-key"
```

Windows 11, PowerShell

```
[Environment]::SetEnvironmentVariable("ELEVENLABS_API_KEY", "your-key", "User")
```

Both Windows commands save the key for your Windows user only. To change or remove it later: Start menu, search **Edit environment variables for your account**.

macOS (zsh, the default shell)

```
echo 'export ELEVENLABS_API_KEY="your-key"' >> ~/.zshrc
```

Linux (bash)

```
echo 'export ELEVENLABS_API_KEY="your-key"' >> ~/.bashrc
```

Check the key is set

These show only whether it is set, without printing the key.

Windows 11, Command Prompt

```
if defined ELEVENLABS_API_KEY (echo set) else (echo NOT set)
```

Windows 11, PowerShell

```
if ($env:ELEVENLABS_API_KEY) { "set" } else { "NOT set" }
```

macOS / Linux

```
[ -n "$ELEVENLABS_API_KEY" ] && echo set || echo "NOT set"
```

Part 4. Test it

In the project folder, with the virtual environment activated (see the README), and with a voice sample made by `imageskin voice-sample`, run the command below. It is the same in Command Prompt, PowerShell, macOS and Linux:

```
imageskin say --voice voice-sample.wav -o hello.wav "Hello there, how are you today?"
```

It should print `Wrote hello.wav (N.N seconds) and word timings to hello.json`. Play `hello.wav` (Command Prompt: `start hello.wav`; PowerShell: `Invoke-Item hello.wav`; macOS: `afplay hello.wav`; Linux: `aplay hello.wav`).

The first run creates a voice in your ElevenLabs account (you can see it under **Voices** on the website, named *ImageSkinForLLM voice-sample*). Later runs reuse it until the voice sample

changes. The voice's id is saved next to the sample in `voice-sample.wav.elevenlabs.json`; this file holds no secret.

If something goes wrong

The error mentions	What to do
set the ELEVENLABS_API_KEY environment variable	The key isn't set in this terminal. Repeat Part 3. After Option B, open a new terminal.
HTTP 401	The key is wrong or was deleted. Copy it again carefully, or create a new key.
HTTP 403 or a message about permissions	The key's restrictions block a feature. Check Text to Speech is <i>Access</i> and Voices is <i>Write</i> .
A message about your plan, voice cloning or subscription	Your plan doesn't include Instant Voice Cloning. Upgrade to Starter or higher (Part 1).
A message about credits, quota or limits	Your monthly credits or the key's credit limit are used up. Raise the limit or wait for the monthly reset.
could not reach ElevenLabs	Check your internet connection, VPN or firewall.

Before you commit or share anything: make sure the key isn't in any file in the project folder. If a key is ever committed or shared by mistake, delete it at once in **Developers > API Keys** (use the ... menu next to the key) and create a new one. Deleting it from Git history is not enough, because copies may already exist.